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Mahatma Gandhi Institute of
Education for Peace and
Sustainable Development

Skill 6: Forgiveness and Gratitude

Module Objectives

By the end of this skill, you will be able to:

- Define forgiveness
- List strategies to practice forgiveness.
- Identify thinking traps to forgiveness.
- Define gratitude
- List strategies to cultivate gratitude
- Apply the tools to practice forgiveness and gratitude

What is forgiveness?

Forgiveness means letting go of anger and resentment towards someone who has hurt us and replacing those negative feelings with more positive and helpful ones.

Forgiving can be tough, but it's important for our mental and emotional health and our relationships with others. Many people think that forgiving someone means forgetting what they did, accepting it, or saying it was okay—but that's not true. Forgiveness doesn't mean you're weak; it actually shows strength.

When we forgive, we free ourselves from the burden of negative emotions and allow room for peace and well-being. For example, if a friend betrays your trust, forgiving them doesn't mean you have to forget what happened or act like it didn't hurt. Instead, it means choosing not to let anger control you and focusing on your own peace of mind. Forgiving someone isn't something that happens overnight, but there are tools and practices that can help make it easier over time.

In the next section we discuss the strategies to cultivate forgiveness and analyze what stops us from practicing forgiveness.

Strategies to cultivate forgiveness

Understand Causes and Conditions

When someone harms us, we often think that the person alone is to blame for what they did. We forget that there are many factors that might have led to their actions, like their upbringing, friends, genetics, social status, education, or current life situations. For example, if someone yells at you, it might be because they are stressed from work or dealing with personal issues, not because they are a bad person. Interestingly, when we make mistakes, we usually blame the situation rather than our own character. For example, if you miss a deadline, you might blame being too busy, rather than thinking you're irresponsible.

Related Thinking Trap

This strategy helps us avoid the thinking traps of reductive thinking and fatal attribution error. **Reductive thinking** is when we believe something happened due to just one reason, instead of recognizing the many factors involved. **Fatal attribution error** is when we blame someone's behavior on their personality or character, rather than considering external factors like their environment or past experiences.

For instance, if a coworker is rude to you, instead of thinking they are just a rude person (fatal attribution error), consider that they might be under a lot of stress or have had a bad day. By understanding the causes and conditions that influence people's actions, it becomes easier to forgive and let go of resentment. This helps us move towards greater emotional peace and healthier relationships.

Focus on Common Humanity

When we're angry or resentful towards someone, it's easy to think of them as completely different from us. We might say, "They're nothing like me," which makes it easier to stay angry. But if we focus on how we're similar, it can help reduce our anger. For example, if a friend lets you down, instead of thinking, "They don't care about me," you might remember times when you've made mistakes too. This makes it easier to see them as a human being who's not perfect, just like you.

Related Thinking Trap

This strategy helps us avoid the thinking trap of **ignoring our shared humanity**. When we realize that others are just as human and imperfect as we are, we stop holding them to impossible standards. For example, if a colleague does a bad job on a project, instead of seeing them as incompetent, you might think about how you've also made mistakes under pressure. Recognizing that we all have flaws makes it easier to forgive others and let go of resentment.

By focusing on what we share as human beings—like making mistakes, having bad days, or dealing with stress—we can find it easier to forgive and build stronger, more compassionate relationships.

Cultivate Gratitude

When we're trying to forgive someone, cultivating gratitude means thinking about the positive things that person may have done for us, even if they've also hurt us. For some, this might be difficult, and that's okay. In such cases, we can instead focus on how the tough experience taught us something valuable or helped us grow.

For example, if a friend betrayed your trust, it might be hard to think of anything positive about them. But you could try to appreciate how the experience made you stronger or more careful in choosing your friends.

Related Thinking Trap

This strategy helps us avoid the thinking trap of **negativity bias**, where we focus only on the bad things that happened. Instead of dwelling on the hurt, we can shift our focus to the positive aspects of our lives that help us move past anger and resentment. For example, after a difficult breakup, instead of only remembering the pain, you might focus on how it helped you learn more about yourself and what you truly want in a relationship.

By practicing gratitude, we can find it easier to let go of negative feelings and move towards forgiveness, allowing us to heal and grow from difficult experiences.

Activity

Pick one incident from your past where you feel like someone wronged you. Do not pick a traumatic memory, pick something that you can easily work with.

Think of one strategy you think you can apply to try and forgive this person. It is fine even if you think none of these strategies might work, but write about that event and explore if these strategies can help. After completing the activity, reflect on the following questions:

1. How did you feel while reliving that event?
2. Do you think any of these strategies will help you?
3. Did your perspective shift after you attempted to practice forgiveness?

Forgiveness and gratitude are connected.

Gratitude is the recognition of the benefits one receives from others, be it one or more people, other aspects of nature, or a supernatural being or force.

Gratitude recognizes the benefits one receives from others, be it one or more people, other aspects of nature, or a supernatural being or force. Gratitude can be an emotion or trait. As an emotion, it's a feeling of thankfulness and appreciation. As a trait, it refers to a person's disposition toward gratitude.

A person with greater trait-gratitude would experience it more easily and frequently.

In the next section, we discuss the strategies to cultivate gratitude

Strategies to cultivate gratitude

Focus on What One Has Received

This strategy is about appreciating the things our friends and loved ones do for us every day, even if we sometimes take them for granted.

For example, your friend might always listen to you when you're upset, or your partner might help with chores at home. Even if someone didn't do something specifically for you, you can still be thankful for how it benefits you.

Focus on What Others Have Not Done

We usually think of gratitude in terms of what others do for us, but we can also be grateful for what they don't do.

For example, when you're driving or riding, you rely on others to follow the rules of the road. If they drive safely, it prevents accidents, which is something to be thankful for, even though it's easy to overlook.

Focus on What One Has Learned Through the Experience

Even negative experiences can teach us valuable lessons. For example, going through a breakup might be painful, but it could help you understand what you need in a relationship. Losing a job might open the door to better opportunities.

These tough experiences can help us grow stronger and more resilient, a concept known as "post-traumatic growth." Sometimes, the lesson is simply learning what not to do, which is also important.

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Engage in Naikan Practice

Naikan is a reflective practice where you focus on someone important in your life, like your mother, and ask yourself three questions:

1. What have I received from this person?
2. What have I given them in return?
3. What trouble have I caused them?

We don't focus on the trouble they caused us, because our minds naturally lean towards negativity. This practice helps us appreciate the positive impact others have had on our lives. We'll explore this practice more deeply later in the course.

Recognize Interdependence

We often think we're mostly independent, but in reality, we rely on countless others every day. For example, the food you eat involves farmers, truck drivers, grocery store workers, and many more people.

Recognizing how connected we are to others helps us see their actions as acts of kindness. This mindset helps us avoid the thinking trap of believing we're completely self-sufficient when, in fact, we depend on many people to live the way we do.

These strategies help us cultivate gratitude by focusing on the positive aspects of our relationships and experiences, even in situations that might not seem positive at first. By practicing these approaches, we can foster a greater sense of appreciation and well-being in our daily lives.

Naikan Practice

In this section we will discuss the Naikan practice in detail. The Naikan practice which originated in Japan translates to "looking inside" or "introspection." This is a very useful practice for cultivating gratitude and forgiveness.

During the Naikan practice, ask yourself these three questions about a person in your life:

1. What have I received from this person?
2. What have I given this person in return?
3. What troubles have I caused this person?

While practicing this technique, it is important to ensure that you don't think about any troubles this person may have caused you. That's because this is naturally what we think about due to our negativity bias and what we are trying to do now is overcome negative thought patterns that get in the way of your well-being and healthy relationships.

Follow the following steps to do the Naikan Activity and do share your reflections in the text box below. Alternatively, you can also download the activity handout.

1. Bring to mind someone from your life on whom you would like to do Naikan practice. (If this is a person you have known for more than a year, you may wish to choose a specific time period to start with, such as the first year or few years you knew this person, and then continue from there the next time you do this practice.)
2. List all the things you received from this person, being specific.

3. List all the things you have given this person in return.
4. List anything you did that may have caused trouble for this person.

Questions for reflection

1. What thoughts, emotions and sensations arise in your body and mind from doing this practice?
2. When you finish writing, end with bringing to mind a resource or focus on the contact of your body with a surface, object or another body part, and allow yourself to notice any neutral or pleasant sensations that arise in your body.
3. Did you gain any insights from this practice?